

BREAKING INTO COMIC BOOKS

Creating a comic-book perhaps isn't as difficult to get into as producing a film or a TV show, but there are hurdles any budding writers or artists should be aware of. Current Marvel writer Kieron Gillen recalls his journey through the industry, and offers advice for aspiring creators

Like many of the comic-book creators Kieron Gillen, creator of Phonogram, recounted the same nostalgic story of how he originally got into comics, namedropping the books he read in his that inspired them to do so. The only interchangeable details are usually the era, creators and characters. Steve Ditko's run on *Spider-Man* in the Sixties, O'Neil/Adams on Batman in the Seventies, and Frank Miller's acclaimed *Daredevil* run in the Eighties tend to pop up a fair amount, for example. As with any medium, the greatest comic-books have the capacity to turn audience into creators, whether that's via crude childhood drawings, or sophisticated, career-making masterworks.

But not all comic-book creators were inspired in quite the same way. Wanting to know more, we asked someone whose ascent to comic-book fame has been relatively fast. Before working in the industry, Kieron Gillen earned a positive reputation as a games journalist among his peers. He admits, however, that he came into comic-books late – a byproduct of there being no comic-book shop in Stafford, where Gillen hails from, throughout his youth. "Basically, the only thing you had to read were reprints on the news stands or 2000 AD, that sort of thing. I kind of drifted away from it. I got back into comics, even just as a one graphic novel a year guy, when I was 21, and I picked up a copy of *Watchmen*, and I read that. Then I was essentially reading one Vertigo book a year.

"When I was 25, I sort of just fell into it – it was like discovering bookshops or pop music when you're 25. The idea is there's 100 years of history there, and all these classics I know absolutely nothing about. So that's kind of how I came into it; I discovered it really late, and then just fell right, deeply in love with the medium."

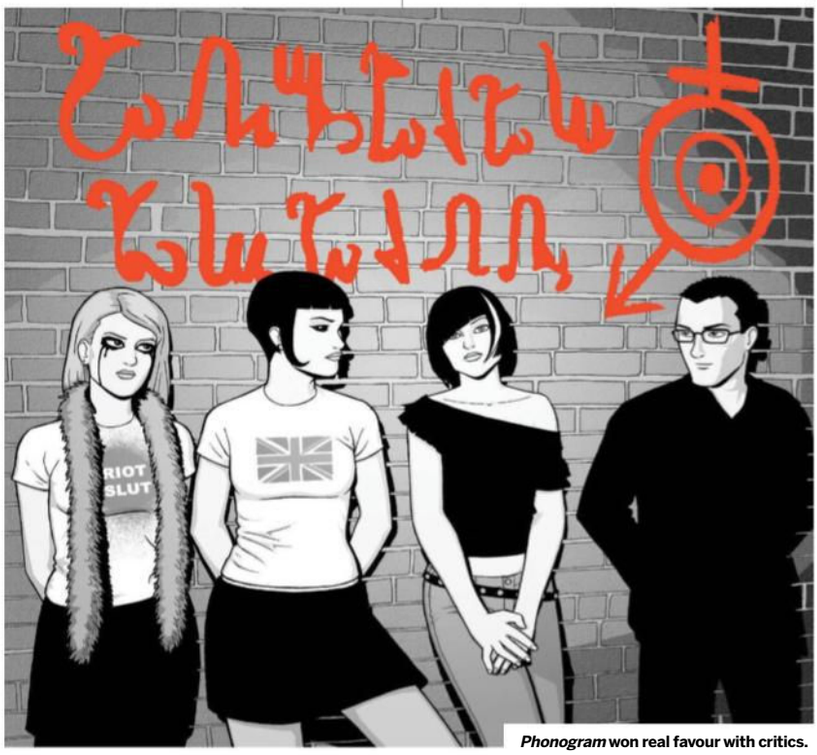
Within six months of that, Gillen had attended his first comic-book convention, written his first script, and even had work printed in the small press. Engaging the scene through forums and conventions was the key to Gillen meeting his first major collaborator, artist Jamie McKelvie, with whom he co-created the Image Comics book *Phonogram*.

"We both kind of came from early Noughties web culture, basically", Gillen recalls. "I was on a couple of forums that Jamie was on as well, and we knew people who knew people. I was basically finding people to collaborate with. And I was selling one of these anthologies, and Jamie came up to the table and said 'hello!' with his impeccable warmth, and showed me his portfolio." Gillen and McKelvie discussed work for an anthology, and they became friends after then. "But the crucible of our relationship was completely around *Phonogram*. That was, I think 2003, and *Phonogram* came out in 2006."

Gillen may have started on lower-profile titles with smaller publishers, but he now co-writes the long-running *Uncanny X-Men*, and writes his own *X-Men* offshoot, *Generation Hope*. This follows a successful run on *Thor*. Within just two years of *Phonogram* hitting shelves, Gillen, after having his independent work championed by the esteemed writer Warren Ellis, was producing scripts for Marvel.

Yet, he doesn't necessarily recommend that anyone sets writing a story for one of the publisher's icons as a target, rather that you should improve your craft and get your work out there first. "Say you actually want to work at Marvel, and you only want to work at Marvel, I'd say that's actually a bad thing. You're a writer, or an artist. This is what you should care about. If you're a writer and you want to work at Marvel, they don't look at your work cold. They look for writers who prove their skill, and the only place you're going to prove your skill is actually going and doing a book with a smaller publisher."

We asked Gillen about his experience pitching *Phonogram*, which seemed to be a combination of knowing the right people and having the correct discipline. "Jamie had also done a book with Eric Stephenson, he's at Image Comics now. *Long Hot Summer*, it's called. So there was



***Phonogram* won real favour with critics.**



***Phonogram: The Singles Club* is available to buy for £10.99.**